

■ By Kaverie Bamzai

At a time when two top Reliance-ADAG officials were holed up in Los Angeles' Four Seasons Hotel hammering out a \$550-million (Rs 21 crore) deal with Steven Spielberg's DreamWorks, on their way to making the entertainment conglomerate the first Indian company to own a Hollywood studio, guess what was the buzz in Bollywood? That two of its biggest stars were no longer on speaking terms after a posh party that almost declined into a brawl, despite a third major star playing peacemaker.

It is a story that has acquired the status of a soap with fresh episodes being aired on news channels and headlined in tabloids every day. A birthday party for Salman Khan's girlfriend Katrina Kaif, supposed to be a mingling of the who's who of Bollywood's 100 best at a swish night spot, became the venue of a verbal showdown. What began gamely enough as banter between Shah Rukh Khan and Salman, who were seated at

capture the event for posterity.

Such dogfights have become increasingly common in Bollywood, and often extend to the respective actor's camps. What was once a great rivalry between Amitabh Bachchan and Shah Rukh over who would inherit Bollywood's crown has now become a free-for-all. The actors snipe at each other through their friends, through the media, their own blogs, TV shows

ture in the eye, and which is happy to lean back on its old economy ways of temper tantrums and closed-in cliques. It's a Bollywood that has found new weapons of warfare to sustain its aura. So Salman will invite Govinda and David Dhawan on his Sony show *Dus Ka Dum*, the Bachchans will travel with Abhishek's buddies Riteish Deshmukh and Preity Zinta for the Unforgettables, Shah Rukh will keep everyone else on

GANG WARS

the same table as Gauri Khan and Aamir Khan, about whose show did better (for the record, Salman's *Dus Ka Dum* has an average rating of 2.3 and Shah Rukh's *Kya Aap Paanchvi Pass Se Tez Hai* has a rating of 2.1) degenerated into a bust-up over Salman's former girlfriend Aishwarya Rai.

Battles over women or work are not new in Bollywood. Dev Anand writes about how he was heartbroken when he saw Zeenat Aman with his great rival Raj Kapoor and Guru Dutt and Dilip Kumar never spoke to each other after the latter stood him up on *Pyaasa*. But the level of nastiness is new. As is the unprecedented interest in Bollywood—just consider, when Aamir left Salman's flat at 5.30 a.m. after the previous day's celebrations, there was a TV crew waiting outside to record his views. And when Shah Rukh left the night spot after Salman shook him by the collar, there were at least 10 news channels to

Bollywood dogfights intensify as the film industry becomes Camp Central with a number of stars picking on each other, using ever new weapons of individual destruction

and even awards (Shah Rukh rarely turns up for the IIFA awards show, of which Bachchan is the brand ambassador). Add star cameos to this warfare and there's more clashing of egos. If Shah Rukh got industry majors, among them Salman, for *Om Shanti Om*, the former refused to return the favour when Salman asked him to do a cameo in his brother's film.

It's typical of ageing Bollywood's insularity, which refuses to look the fu-

hold for Aditya Chopra and Karan Johar, and Akshay Kumar will ensure that only he gets first option on the films of friends Vipul Shah and Sajid Nadiadwala. Oh, and Aamir and Salman will take turns in calling Shah Rukh a dog in their blogs.

Amidst tabloid stories of he-sabotaged-my-show and he-out-promoted-my-movie, neutrality is a casualty. So the non-aligned, one-man band Aamir, fresh from the success of his directorial

